When Short Responses Are Hard to Distinguish in Translation Audits

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Main finding

Short responses offer fewer clues for retrieval. Translation quality requires separate evidence.

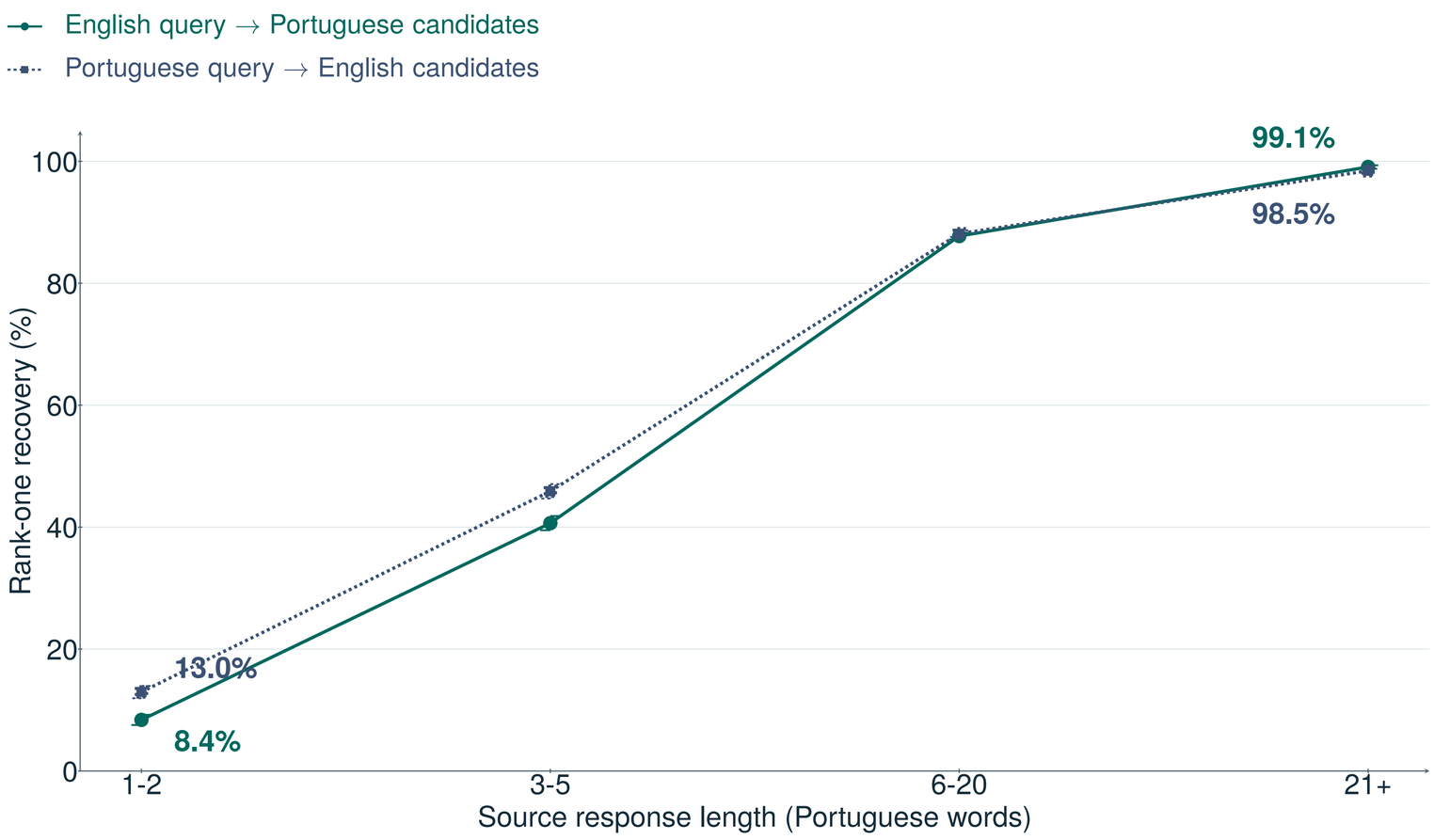
44,118
Portuguese-English pairs

14,706
Survey-specific records

4
Workplace surveys

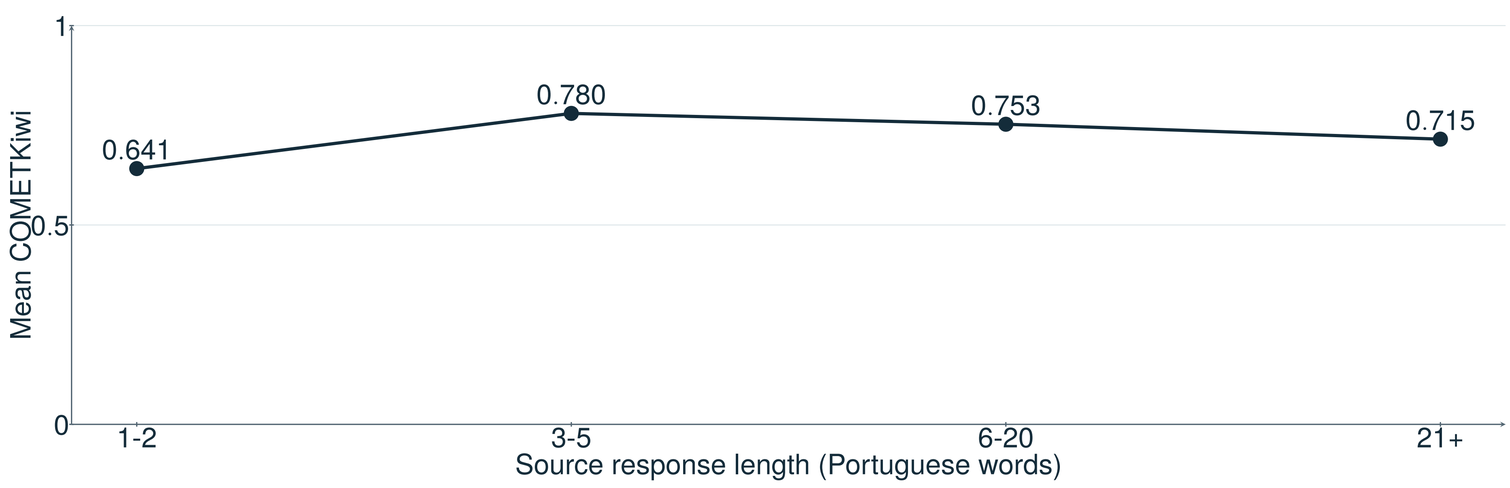
Retrieval rises with response length

Rank-one recovery finds the paired text or an exact normalized duplicate in the first position.



Error bars show 95% bootstrap intervals from 2,000 resamples, clustered by survey-specific record. All queries search the full set of 44,118 candidates.

Quality estimates follow a different pattern



COMETKiwi estimates learned translation quality. Human ratings would calibrate these scores for short survey text.

Study and audit

Archived translations from Brazilian workplace surveys. One third of pairs come from mental-health or well-being prompts. Each record contributes three answers.

Retrieval

Qwen3-Embedding-4B
8B model-scale sensitivity

Quality estimation

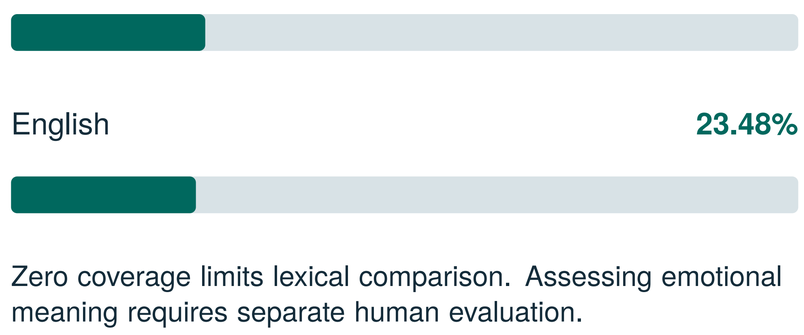
COMETKiwi DA-XL
Source + translation

Language and coverage

Lingua + EmoAtlas
Language labels and emotion lexicons

Emotion-lexicon coverage has gaps

Share of responses with zero emotion-lexicon coverage



Zero coverage limits lexical comparison. Assessing emotional meaning requires separate human evaluation.

Interpret each measure on its own

Report length, repetition and coverage alongside scores. Bilingual human review is needed to assess translation accuracy and emotional or cultural equivalence.

Evidence comes from automated criteria in one setting and language pair. Translation provenance is incomplete. Survey comments remain confidential.

Paper

Code

Paper, code and synthetic tests
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Methods Zhang et al., 2025, Qwen3 Embedding | Rei et al., 2022 and 2023, COMETKiwi | Semeraro et al., 2025, EmoAtlas